Beijing a strategic outpost in the Indian Ocean, where its naval ships routinely transit. China similarly took a 70 percent stake in an equally useful port in Myanmar the same year. While all of this helps China's OBOR initiative, it also gives the Chinese navy vital access to important waterways. Beijing now appears to be setting its sights on the South Pacific, extending aid to island nations in a bid to reduce American, Australian, and Japanese influence.

These attempts to buy influence or force accommodation to China's wishes are complemented by another of the new China rules: a propaganda and influence campaign to squelch any criticism of the country or its policies. Western observers often underestimate the importance the CCP puts on the ideological competition with the rest of the world. In his first year in power, Xi Jinping released a "Communiqué on the Current State of the Ideological Sphere," colloquially known as Document 9.[49] The communiqué made clear the CCP's view of the "complicated, intense struggle" with the West over "false ideological trends." The party and Chinese society were enjoined to defend themselves from the concept of "Western constitutional democracy" and to avoid the promotion of "universal values," "civil society," and "neoliberalism," all of which threatened the party and socialism with Chinese characteristics. As much as the defense of the CCP and its system lay at home, the ideological struggle also would be waged abroad, through a global propaganda apparatus and widespread influence operations.

Here, Beijing has found all-too-willing counterparts in both foreign businesses and governments, all of whom find it easier to buckle under increasingly outrageous Chinese demands than to risk losing their economic access by taking a critical stand. Their fear is based on China's undeniable economic prowess. In just twenty years, from 1997 to 2016, China's exports exploded from $211 billion to an astonishing $2 trillion—a tenfold increase—making money for Chinese and Westerners alike while reducing consumer prices around the globe.[50] But with China's new strength has come a bare-knuckle abusiveness, often combined with an unexpected sense of insecurity, and it seems increasingly clear that Beijing expects the West to change how it thinks and